

PROMPTING STRATEGIES

THE STRANGER · PRESENTER SHEET · 12 MINUTES

THE ROLEPLAY — THREE ACTS

You are the Stranger. A volunteer is the Asker. The app is on the projector behind you; run the same states on it as you say them out loud.

ACT I — CONTEXT

~3 min

"I am a stranger on a street corner. I am not stupid. I know a great deal about almost everything. I have never met you."

1. The Asker says only: *"Help me get ready for my test."* Answer out loud, as blandly and generally as you honestly can. Cover every case. Do not clown it — a real assistant is competent here, just aimed at nobody.
2. Ask the room: what would I have needed to know? Take three answers, put them on the board.
3. The Asker reads the context block. Answer again, aimed at that kid.

"I didn't get smarter. You got specific."

ACT II — THE TARGET DECK

~4 min

Hold the eight cards from page two face down. "Somebody has to decide what a good answer looks like. If you don't decide, I do. And I never tell you what I picked."

1. Same question, context on, no success spec. **Draw a card and do not show it.** Answer to the card — if it says exhaustive, talk for forty-five seconds without stopping.
2. Now show the card. Wait for the room.
3. Draw a different card. Same question, answer again. Same asker, same words, different answer — and the difference was never theirs.
4. The Asker reads the success spec. Put the deck down and slide it across the table, away from you. On the app, the deck lives *inside* lever 2: flip it on and the three card names get struck out where they sit. Same gesture, same panel.

"You just took the deck out of my hands."

ON THE APP

? is the **Guide**: what every control does. It opens itself on load. ⚙ beside it is Settings — **Open Presenter Notes** (this sheet, on screen; or press **N**), **Presentation mode** (the projector build: big type, the 1–10 score strip, compare, and the card picker inside lever 2) and **Reset**.

Reset is a fresh load without the reload: question 1, levers off, no answer on screen, scoreboard cleared. It deliberately leaves Presentation mode where you set it, so resetting between classes never drops you into student mode.

ACT III — THE FOLDERS

~4 min

Three labelled folders or sheets: **BIOLOGY**, **BRIDGES**, **WRITING AT WORK**. *"I have a folder on nearly everything. The words you use decide which one I open."*

1. The Asker: *"Why do bridges stay up?"* Open nothing. Answer in plain words: the bottom gets stretched, the top gets squished. All true. All unusable.
2. The Asker adds the keyword block. Open **BRIDGES** and answer in the real vocabulary — load path, bending moment, neutral axis, section depth.
3. On the app, press **H**. Count aloud the expert words in the answer that the Asker never typed.

"You didn't know those words. You didn't have to. You only had to point at the folder."

HOUSE RULES

1. **The Stranger is never stupid.** The honest failure of a bare prompt is blandness, not garbage. The demo dies the moment the bad answer looks rigged.
2. **No trick answers.** If the prompt supports a good answer, give a good answer.
3. **Every answer gets a number.** 1–10, from the room, out loud, on the board before the next one.
4. **Nobody says "the AI is bad at this"** without naming which lever is off.
5. **The Asker types nothing they wouldn't really type.** No fair inventing a great prompt to prove a point.

RUNNING ORDER

0:00	Cold open. Act I, live, no screen.
3:00	App, scenario 1, all levers off. Draw the card. Score it.
4:30	One lever at a time. Score each. The curve argues for you.
7:00	Act III on the bridge scenario. Highlighter on, count the words.
9:30	"Which lever would fix this?" — two rounds, hands up.
11:00	Closing slide. Read the line. Stop talking.

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. The first answer was accurate. Why was it useless?
2. Who decided what a good answer looked like, and when?
3. The expert answer used words you never typed. Where did they come from, and how did asking in plain words keep them hidden?
4. Which of the three levers is hardest to pull for a subject you know nothing about? What do you do then?
5. Name a time you blamed a tool for an answer you had underspecified.
6. Success spec means saying what "done" looks like. When is that hard to say — and what does that tell you about the task itself?

The app is one HTML file and touches no network. Every answer in it was written by hand before the file was saved: there is no model behind the glass.
Keys: **1 2 3** levers · **Enter** ask · **Space** skip typing · **H** highlight · **R** replay card · **P** pin to compare · **S** scoreboard · **M** student mode · **N** these notes.

The target deck — cut along the dashed lines

Eight editorial choices somebody has to make. When the Asker doesn't make them, the machine does, silently. Hold these face down; draw one whenever the success-spec lever is off.



Length: exhaustive

Cover everything that could possibly be relevant. Leave nothing out.

Turns up in: test · email



Audience: someone who missed the whole semester

Assume they know nothing. Define every term before using it.

Turns up in: test



Format: dense paragraphs

No headings. No bullets. Flowing prose, start to finish.

Turns up in: test · essay



Length: short and safe

Keep it brief. Don't risk being wrong about the details.

Turns up in: bridge



Format: numbered listicle

Everything as a numbered list. Ten items. Equal weight to each.

Turns up in: bridge · email



Audience: an expert peer

Assume deep familiarity. Skip the basics, get to the interesting part.

Turns up in: bridge · essay



Tone: encouraging coach

Lead with affirmation. Soften every critique. Protect motivation.

Turns up in: essay



Coverage: hedge every claim

Present all sides. Avoid committing to one recommendation.

Turns up in: email